Activity 02 - Evidence Interview and Root-Cause Map at HarborLink Logistics

Course: Mastering The Art of Conflict Resolution to Foster Team Collaboration and Success (TGS-2023021752) Duration: 55 minutes Materials: Interview guide | evidence matrix | root-cause map Output: Neutral interview notes, an evidence matrix and a root-cause map that distinguishes task, process, relationship and structural causes.

Objective

Gather and validate conflict information through neutral interviews and root-cause analysis.

Psychological-safety boundary

Use only the fictional case. Do not require anyone to disclose a personal conflict. Any participant may call a pause or request another role. This learning activity does not replace organisational policy, HR advice or legal advice.

Scenario

At HarborLink Logistics, warehouse lead Priya says transport planner Daniel repeatedly changes dispatch priorities without warning. Daniel says Priya's team ignores urgent customer requests and hides picking delays until late afternoon. The shared dashboard records timestamps but not who approved priority changes. A new performance incentive rewards each function differently. Learners conduct two short interviews and build a root-cause map before recommending any resolution.

Detailed instructions

Role cards

Give each participant only their own role before the first round. Observers use the checklist.

Neutral Interviewer

Goal: obtain a fair, usable account. Private brief: Sets scope, avoids promises of absolute secrecy and asks evidence-based questions.

Priya | Warehouse Lead

Goal: protect safe, stable picking work. Private brief: Has examples of last-minute changes and overtime, but also makes assumptions about intent.

Daniel | Transport Planner

Goal: meet urgent delivery commitments. Private brief: Has customer escalations and believes the warehouse is withholding information.

1. Define the interview purpose. Write a neutral purpose statement: understand sequence, impact, evidence, interests and constraints before recommending action.

2. Set boundaries. Explain the interviewer's role, respectful conduct, note-taking, how information may be used and why absolute confidentiality cannot be promised.

3. Prepare comparable questions. Create six open questions that both Priya and Daniel will receive, including what happened, when, impact, direct evidence, needs and a workable future state.

4. Assign roles. Form groups of three and assign interviewer, Priya and Daniel. Role holders read only their own brief and may elaborate without inventing serious allegations.

5. Interview Priya. Provide uninterrupted opening time, paraphrase key points and ask for specific examples. Mark direct knowledge, hearsay and interpretation separately.

6. Interview Daniel. Use comparable time and questions. Test the sequence without cross-examining or signalling agreement with either account.

7. Build the evidence matrix. For each disputed point, record account A, account B, available record, corroboration, confidence and what remains to be checked.

8. Identify interests. Translate fixed positions into interests such as safety, predictability, customer commitments, workload control and fair accountability.

9. Map root causes. Sort contributors into task, process, relationship and structural lenses. Include the missing approval trail and conflicting incentives.

10. Test alternatives. Write at least two plausible explanations for the conflict pattern. Identify what evidence would strengthen or weaken each explanation.

11. Recommend next fact-finding. Prioritise no more than three additional checks and name who should obtain them and by when.

12. Debrief fairness. Ask whether each party had equal voice, whether language stayed neutral and whether the diagnosis avoids a premature finding.

Suggested timing

- 5 minutes - Purpose, boundaries and questions
- 14 minutes - Two interviews
- 12 minutes - Evidence matrix
- 10 minutes - Interests and root-cause map
- 7 minutes - Alternative explanations
- 4 minutes - Next checks
- 3 minutes - Fairness debrief

Discussion questions

- Which questions reveal sequence, impact, evidence and underlying interests?
- What information should be validated before deciding on blame or remedy?
- Which root causes sit in the work system rather than either person's character?
- What facts remain unknown, and how will you record that uncertainty?

Submission

Submit the completed worksheet and checklist. Use role names rather than real personal data, mark unresolved information as unknown and retain the artefact only through the approved course channel.

Debrief

The diagnosis shows a traceable evidence chain, at least two plausible causes and unanswered questions before strategy selection.